

determine which performs best with a particular rifle. Once the preferred lots are identified, the ammunition is marked for dispatch to India through the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI). A cycle that could earlier be completed in roughly three to four months has now stretched beyond a year.

Incidentally, the previous order placed by the Indian federation in June 2025 has only reached selected athletes this August and in limited quantities. Meanwhile, an appointment request with Lapua's Berlin facility, the testing centre regularly used by India's top shooters, currently returns a slot in December 2026.

A like-for-like?

The obvious solution would be to find alternatives. That, however, has proved easier said than done.

"The NRAI did think of replacements in Eley (Birmingham, UK) and RWS (Fuerth, Germany)," India's 50m rifle head coach Manoj Kumar said.

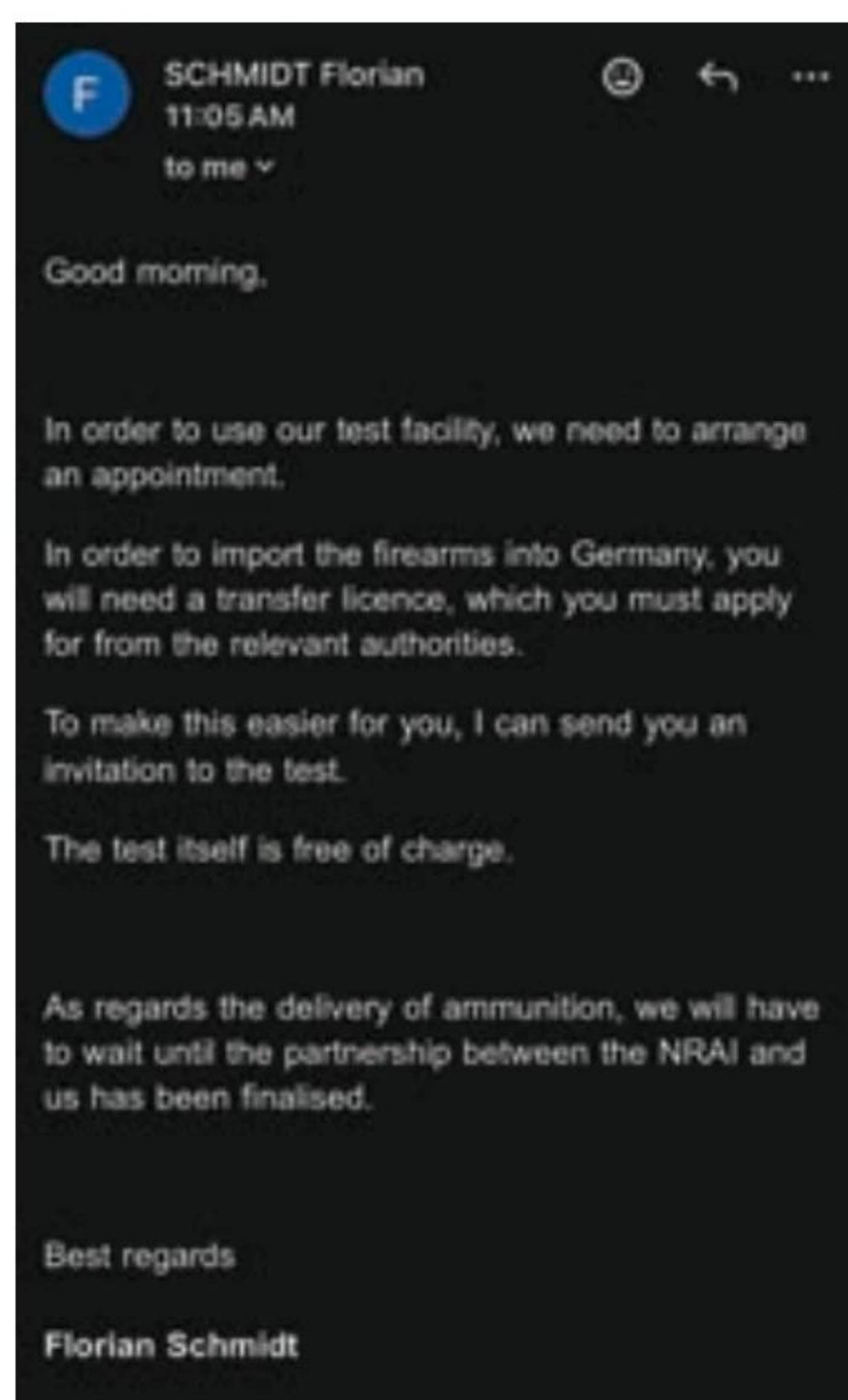
Eley is largely available to Indian shooters, but there are reservations over its performance. "Accuracy matters. A grouping of 11-12 mm (average deviations from the mean mark on the target) while testing a particular barrel generally means the ammo is of very good quality. But when we ran the tests on Eley, we got groupings of 15-16 mm. On the scoresheet, if you take out human error, it would translate to your 10.1, 10.2, or 10.0s dropping to a 9.9 or 9.8," Manoj said.

That, however, does not render Eley unusable. Several shooters continue to prefer it. In India's 25m pistol team, for instance, Esha Singh and Manu Bhaker prefer Lapua's softer recoil, while Rahi Sarnobat is more comfortable with Eley.

Bibaswan Ganguly, chief rifle coach of the Meghalaya State team,

says RWS' R50 ammunition, although widely available, is difficult to bring into India because of contractual and import-related issues involving the NRAI.

"One of my students recently sent a request to use their test facility. While they were willing to arrange that for free, importing would have been an issue," Ganguly says. "I haven't seen the R50 in India, perhaps in the last 15 years or so. The only way we can use RWS is going abroad and buying, shooting and depositing the empties there before flying back."



For shooters, the consequences of the shortage go beyond procurement headaches. Ammunition is part of the athlete's confidence, believes Olympian Joydeep Karmakar. He said, "If you don't get good ammunition in training, your confidence will go down. The score you get when shooting is a combination of a lot of things: your gut feel, senses, and muscle memory. And the score

matters. No one has matured to the point where they have confidence in themselves to the point that they ignore the score altogether. Now, if there is bad ammunition, it will create self-doubt. You will be confused as to whether the bullet is the problem or you are technically doing something wrong."

A shadow of doubt

Ashi Chouksey knows that feeling only too well. The Asiad-bound shooter has established herself as one of India's leading 3P competitors. She shot a 598 at last year's Dehradun National Games and has since continued to perform at a high level.

At the recently concluded World Cup in Hangzhou, she was forced to use three-year-old ammunition because newer stock was unavailable. The consequences became clear during the event.

After shooting a strong 193 in kneeling despite fluctuating winds, Chouksey began her prone series with three inner-10s. Then came a shot that sounded different. She immediately knew something was wrong. The display showed an 8. "And I just stood transfixed," Ashi recalled.

"I neither gave any clicks nor made any adjustment to my right foot because I knew it was not my mistake. When I asked the coach, he gave me a simple answer that we don't have any ammunition other than this (the ones from Paris 2024 Olympics). He asked me to just finish it off. But that is not something an athlete wants to hear. I can't just finish it off like that. I want to perform well. I can't even forget about that day." She finished 23rd that day; the lone 8 had planted a seed of doubt. In a precision sport, fractions of a millimetre can separate finalists from the rest.

For Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar,